CAPSTONE 02 · RESEARCH INTELLIGENCE BRIEF · SOLUTION BRIEF

How to research a decision, and check it, step by step.

Ten steps across one week. You frame the decision, let Research do the reading, then do the part it cannot: decide which claims you trust.

TOTAL TIME	STEPS	WORKED EXAMPLE	PLAN
About five hours	Ten, in order	Meera picks a new sales channel	Pro or above, for Research

THE FLOW

STEPS 01-02	STEPS 03-04	STEPS 05-07	STEP 08	STEPS 09-10
Frame	**Research**	**Discern**	**Decide**	**Write**
The decision, the options and the criteria, before any search.	A cited, multi-source report, read once with a pen.	A claim register. The critical claims checked at source.	Options scored on the same criteria, with only checked evidence.	The brief, then the note on what you verified and changed.

THE WEEK

DAY 1	DAY 2	DAY 3	DAY 4	DAY 5
Frame and run	**Read and log**	**Verify**	**Gaps and options**	**Write**
Write the frame, send the Research prompt. Steps 01-03 · 1 h	Read the report, build the claim register. Steps 04-05 · 1 h	Open the sources behind every critical claim. Step 06 · 1.5 h	Close the gaps, score the options. Steps 07-08 · 1 h	The brief and the verification note. Steps 09-10 · 1.5 h

BEFORE YOU START

- [ ] A Pro, Max, Team or Enterprise plan. Research is not on Free.
- [ ] **Web search** turned on. Research does not run without it.
- [ ] A decision that is still open, with a deadline and an owner.
- [ ] Two quiet hours on Day 3 for reading sources.
- [ ] A sheet or table for your claim register.

WORKED EXAMPLE · MEERA

Meera, marketing manager at Lumen, has to tell the founder which sales channel to add next quarter: quick-commerce apps, a bigger marketplace push, or neither. The founder decides at the board meeting on 15 December.

The claims, figures and scores in Meera's example are illustrative. They show the method, not real market data.

01

30 MINUTES · DAY 1

Frame the decision before you search.

Research answers the question you ask: a topic gets a survey, a framed decision gets evidence you can use.

TEMPLATE · THE DECISION FRAME

Decision: [a question that ends in a choice]
Owner and deadline: [who decides, by when]
Options: [2–3 real options, including "do nothing" if it is one]
Criteria and weights: [3–5 criteria that add up to 100%]
What I already know: [facts you trust, with their source]
What would change my mind: [the one finding that would flip it]

WORKED EXAMPLE · MEERA'S FRAME

Decision	Which channel should Lumen add in Q1 2027?
Owner, deadline	The founder, at the board meeting on 15 December
Options	A · quick-commerce pilot in two cities B · bigger marketplace push C · neither: invest in our own site
Criteria	Margin after fees 30% · Cash tied up in stock 25% · Speed to revenue 20% · Brand control 15% · Team effort 10%
Change my mind	If quick-commerce fees for beauty are far lower than we assume

× AVOID "Tell me about quick-commerce." A topic is not a decision. Name the options and what you will judge them on.

✓ CHECK Your frame names an owner, a deadline, 2–3 options and weighted criteria that add up to 100%.

02

5 MINUTES · DAY 1 · MODULE 4.2

Turn on web search and Research.

`New chat` → `Web search: on` → `Research` → `Paste your prompt`

01 Start a new chat, inside your Capstone 01 Project if the decision belongs to that work.

02 Turn on **web search** first, then turn on **Research**, both beside the message box. Research needs web search to run.

03 With Google Workspace connected, Research also searches your Gmail, Calendar and Docs. Turn them off for web only.

✓ CHECK Both controls show as on before you send. If Research does not start, ask directly: "Please use the research tool to…"

03

20 MINUTES, THEN 5-45 MINUTES WAITING · DAY 1

Write the Research prompt from your frame.

Paste your frame in, then tell Research exactly what evidence to bring back and how to label it. The labels are what make step 05 fast.

TEMPLATE · RESEARCH PROMPT

I am [role] preparing a recommendation for [owner] by [deadline]. Here is my decision frame: [paste]

For each option, find evidence against each criterion. Bring back figures with their date and source. Prefer primary sources: official filings, company announcements, regulator data and named surveys over blogs and roundups. Mark every figure as reported, estimated or forecast. Where sources disagree, show both and say which is more credible and why. Cite every claim. End with what you could not find.

WORKED EXAMPLE · HOW MEERA'S PROMPT OPENS

"I'm the marketing manager at Lumen, a direct-to-consumer skincare brand in India, preparing a recommendation for our founder by 15 December. Here is my decision frame…" She then pastes the frame from step 01 and the instructions above, unchanged.

01 Send it, and let it run. Research usually takes 5 to 15 minutes, and complex questions can take longer. You do not need to keep the tab open.

02 Save the report as soon as it arrives: copy it into a doc, or ask Claude to turn it into an Artifact.

✓ CHECK The report covers every option against every criterion, and every factual sentence carries a citation.

04

30 MINUTES · DAY 2

Read the report once, with a pen.

01 Read the whole report before acting on any of it. Note your first reaction: which option it seems to favour, and why.

02 Highlight every **claim**: a figure, a ranking, a cause, or a statement about what a company or regulator did.

03 Mark each claim **critical** if your recommendation would change were it false. Everything else is background.

04 Circle any claim with no citation, a citation to a page that is not a source (a search page, a homepage), or a figure with no date.

× AVOID Trusting the summary at the top. Summaries smooth over the hedges that the body of the report still contains.

✓ CHECK You have a marked-up report, and can say in one sentence which three claims your decision rests on most.

05

45 MINUTES · DAY 2 · DISCERNMENT

Build the claim register.

The register is where discernment becomes visible. One row per claim you highlighted: the claim in your words, the source the report gave, whether it is critical, and later your verdict. It becomes the backbone of your verification note.

COLUMN	WHAT GOES IN IT
#	A number, so the brief can refer to it
Claim	The claim in your own words, with the exact figure, unit and date
Cited source	Publisher, title and link, as the report gave it
Critical?	Yes if your recommendation changes when the claim is false
What you checked	Filled in step 06: what you opened and what you found
Verdict	Confirmed, corrected, weakened, rejected or unverifiable

WORKED EXAMPLE · FOUR ROWS FROM MEERA'S REGISTER · ILLUSTRATIVE

#	CLAIM	CITED SOURCE	CRITICAL?	VERDICT
3	Quick-commerce apps take a commission of about 25% on beauty	Industry blog, March	Yes	CORRECTED
5	Marketplace beauty sales grew faster than quick-commerce last year	Consultancy report	Yes	CONFIRMED
8	Brands must hold 30 days of stock in each dark store	Forum thread	Yes	REJECTED
11	Average basket on quick-commerce is under ₹500	News article quoting a CEO	No	WEAKENED

Use these five verdicts, and only these, so your note reads consistently.

CONFIRMED	The source exists and says what the report says, and the source is fit for purpose
CORRECTED	The source exists but the figure, date or scope differs. You use the source's version
WEAKENED	The source says it, but it is old, partial or has a stake in the answer. You keep it, with a caveat
REJECTED	The source does not say it, does not load, or is not a credible source. You drop the claim
UNVERIFIABLE	Behind a paywall or login. You may not rest the decision on it

✓ CHECK Every highlighted claim has a row, and every row is marked critical or not.

06

90 MINUTES · DAY 3 · DISCERNMENT

Check every critical claim at its source.

This is the step most people skip, and the one the capstone is graded on most heavily. Work down the critical rows of your register. For each claim, run the six checks below in order and stop at the first one that fails.

01 **Open the link.** Does it load, and is it the document the report named? A homepage or search page is not a source.

02 **Find the sentence.** Use find-in-page for the figure. Does the source say the same number, in the same unit, for the same period and the same market?

03 **Read around it.** Is the figure a forecast, an estimate, a "up to", or a single example presented as typical?

04 **Ask who published it.** A company describing its own results, a vendor's sponsored survey or a blog repeating another blog each carry less weight than a regulator, a filing or a named study.

05 **Check the date.** Is it recent enough for a decision about next quarter? Markets that move fast make last year's figures weak.

06 **Corroborate.** For any figure the recommendation depends on, find one independent source that agrees, or say plainly that you could not.

RED FLAGS

- A figure with no date or no unit
- The same round number on many sites, with no origin
- A survey run by a company that sells the answer
- A quote attributed to a person with no link to where they said it
- A link that 404s, or lands on a different page

WORKED EXAMPLE · MEERA CHECKS CLAIM 8

The report said brands must hold 30 days of stock in each dark store. The citation was a forum thread. She opened it: one seller describing their own contract, not a rule. She searched the platform's seller pages and found no such requirement. Verdict: **rejected**. Without it, option A ties up far less cash than she first thought.

Record what you did in the register's "What you checked" column, in one line: what you opened, what you found. Keep a list of rejected claims with the reason. Your verification note needs it.

× AVOID Asking Claude whether its own citation is right. Open the source yourself. That is the skill this capstone tests.

✓ CHECK Every critical claim has a verdict and a one-line record of what you opened.

07

30 MINUTES · DAY 4

Close the gaps your checks opened.

01 List what the rejected and unverifiable claims leave unanswered. Usually it is two or three specific facts.

02 Ask in the same chat, so Claude keeps the context. Name the claim, why you rejected it, and the kind of source you need.

03 Check the new answers the same way as step 06 before they go in your register.

> Claim 8 was rejected: the only source was a forum post describing one seller's contract. Find primary information on stock requirements for beauty brands on the main quick-commerce apps in India, from the platforms' own seller documentation or from reporting that quotes it. If you cannot find it, say so.

✓ CHECK Each gap is either filled with a checked source or recorded as a known unknown.

08

45 MINUTES · DAY 4

Weigh the options on the same criteria.

01 Score each option 1 to 5 on each criterion, using only claims marked confirmed, corrected or weakened.

02 Multiply each score by the criterion's weight and add them up. Show the arithmetic.

03 If the top two are close, say so, and name the criterion that separates them. That is what the decision really turns on.

04 For each option, write one line: what would have to be true for this to be the right choice?

WORKED EXAMPLE · MEERA'S OPTIONS · SCORES ILLUSTRATIVE

CRITERION	WEIGHT	A · QUICK-COMMERCE	B · MARKETPLACE	C · OWN SITE
Margin after fees	30%	2	3	4
Cash tied up in stock	25%	2	4	3
Speed to revenue	20%	5	3	1
Brand control	15%	3	2	5
Team effort	10%	2	4	2
Weighted total	**100%**	**2.75**	**3.20**	**3.10**

B and C sit 0.10 apart, so the decision turns on speed to revenue: B wins only if Lumen needs new revenue this quarter. Option A drops to last largely because claim 3 was corrected upward.

✓ CHECK Every score traces to a claim in the register, and the totals add up when you redo them.

09

60 MINUTES · DAY 5

Write the brief, recommendation first.

Two to four pages. The reader should know your answer from the first paragraph, and be able to check any claim from the sources list. You may ask Claude to draft from your register and matrix, but every sentence must survive your own check.

SECTION	WHAT GOES IN IT	LENGTH
1 · Recommendation	The option you recommend, the main reason, and the condition it depends on	1 para
2 · The decision	What is being decided, by whom, by when, and why now	1 para
3 · Options weighed	The scored matrix, and the criterion that separates the top two	table
4 · Evidence	The claims behind each score, each with a numbered citation you have opened	1 page
5 · Risks	What could go wrong, and what would change your recommendation	½ page
6 · Sources	Numbered list: publisher, title, date, link and date you accessed it	list

WORKED EXAMPLE · MEERA'S OPENING PARAGRAPH

"I recommend option B: a bigger push on the two marketplaces where we already sell, starting in January. It scores highest on the criteria we agreed, mainly because it ties up the least cash [4][7]. The case rests on one condition: that we want new revenue this quarter. If we can wait two quarters, investing in our own site (option C) scores almost as well and keeps more margin [2]. I do not recommend quick-commerce yet: corrected fee figures put its margin well below the other two [3]."

01 Cite with numbers in square brackets that match the sources list. Cite only sources you opened.

02 Where a claim was weakened, say so in the sentence: "one company's own figures suggest…".

03 Ask Claude to stress-test the draft: *"Steelman the strongest objection to this recommendation. Which claim, if wrong, would hurt it most?"* Answer the objection in section 5.

× AVOID Burying the answer under background. If the recommendation is not in the first three lines, move it.

✓ CHECK The recommendation is in the first paragraph, every citation number resolves to a source you opened, and the brief is 2–4 pages.

10

30 MINUTES · DAY 5

Write the verification note, then submit.

One page that shows your discernment. Write it straight from your register.

TEMPLATE · VERIFICATION NOTE

Sources in the report: [n]. Sources I opened: [n], including every source behind a critical claim.
Confirmed: [claim numbers].
Corrected: [claim number: what it said → what the source says].
Rejected: [claim number: reason].
Unverifiable: [claim number: why, and how I treated it].
What changed in the brief: [the scores, sentences or recommendation that moved, and why].

WORKED EXAMPLE · FROM MEERA'S NOTE

"Rejected claim 8 (30 days of stock per dark store): the only source was one seller's forum post, and the platform's seller pages state no such rule. Corrected claim 3: the cited blog gave one rate, but the platform's own seller page showed a higher range for beauty. Together these moved option A's cash score from 1 to 2 and its margin score from 3 to 2."

BEFORE YOU SUBMIT

- [ ] A real, open decision with owner and deadline
- [ ] Report produced in Research mode
- [ ] Claim register with a verdict on every critical claim
- [ ] Brief: recommendation first, 2–3 options, 2–4 pages
- [ ] Every citation opened by you
- [ ] Verification note: one page, rejections explained

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

No Research button	It needs a paid plan, and web search turned on first.
Research does not start	Say "Please use the research tool to…" at the start of the prompt.
Source is paywalled	Find another source, or mark it unverifiable and do not rest on it.
Sources disagree	Report the range, and say which you trust and why.
The report is generic	Your frame lacked options or criteria. Re-run from step 01.